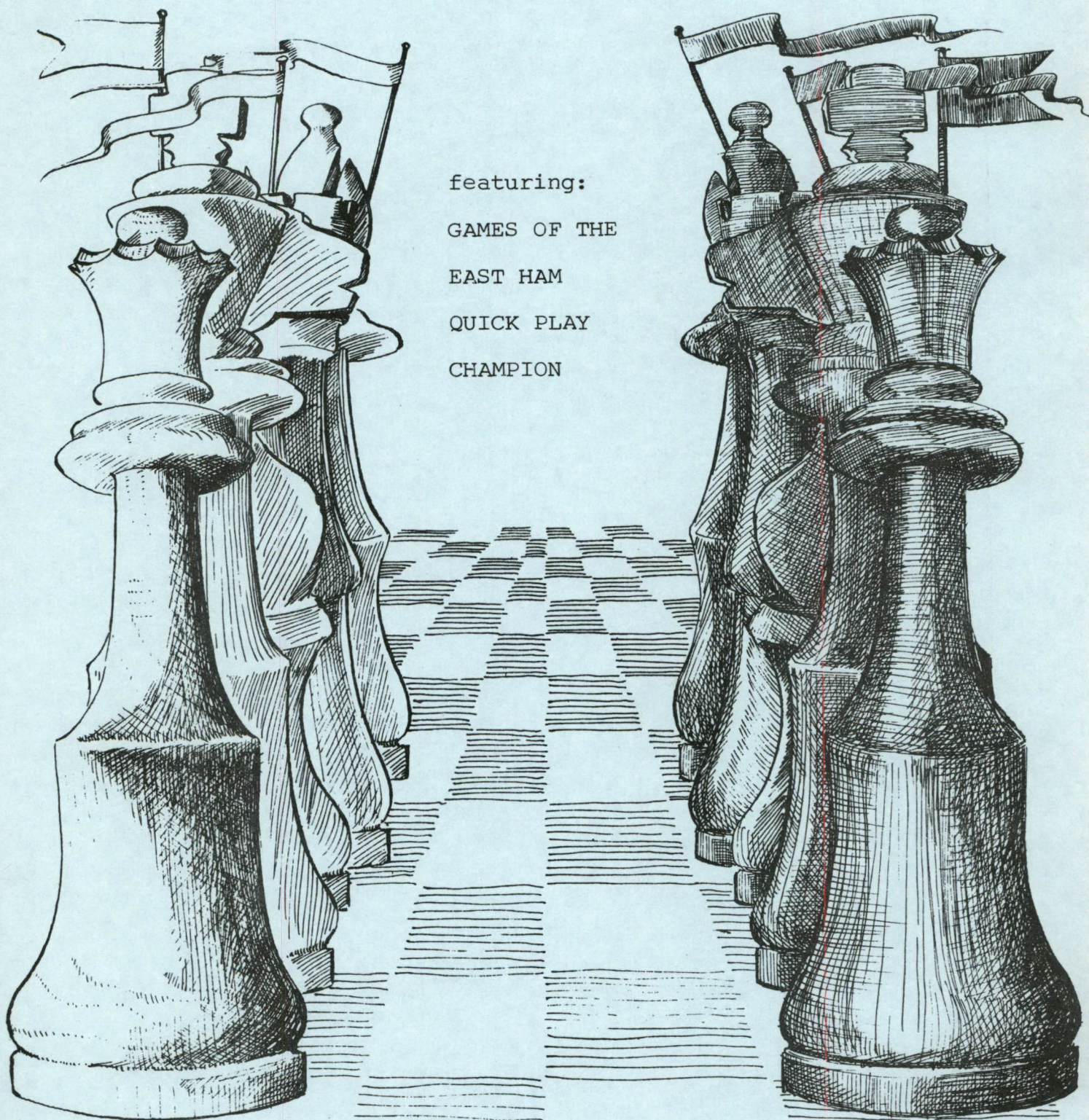


POPULAR CHESS

No. 15

featuring:

GAMES OF THE
EAST HAM
QUICK PLAY
CHAMPION



THE EAST HAM QUICK PLAY CHAMPION STRIKES AGAIN!

by Michael Basman

Taking time off from training juniors to play in a Quickplay tournament at East Ham, I was surprised to find only 30 entrants and no IMs at all.

However, the games were not all easy as 'no-one is a pushover', and I just scraped through to win the title and a large trophy on tie-break. The games will be of interest to our readers, as they contain one Colle, two Grobs, a Polish, a Bc5 Sicilian, and a Larsen opening.

Round 1: the Colle

White. M. Basman

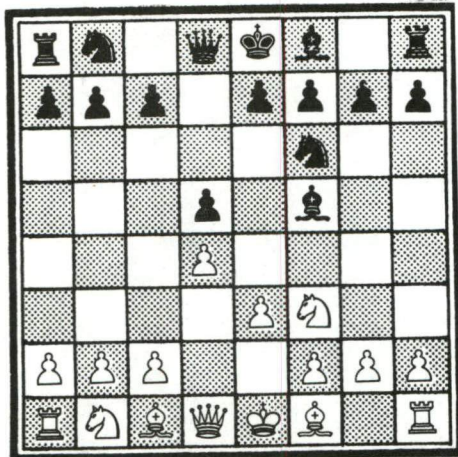
Black. Unsworth

24th Oct. 1987

1 d4 Nf6
2 Nf3 d5

If black plays another move besides 2...d5, the Torre Attack (3 Bg5) is appropriate; see Popular Chess No 7. Otherwise the Colle System is a good idea.

3 e3 Bf5



This 'prevents' white from continuing with his Colle plan of Bd3, Nbd2, 0-0 and e4, though I suppose 4 Bd3 Bxd3 5 Qxd3 (or cxd3) is still possible. Black may also answer 4 Bd3 with ...e6 or ...g6, so that after Bxf5 xf5, he has a firm grip on the e4 square.

4 c4!

This is a suitable reply to ...Bf5. White's queen arriving at b3 and attacking b7 is now an annoyance.

4 ... e6

5 Qb3

Firing the first shot; black

can now gamble with 5...Nc6!? 6 Qxb7 Nb4! threatening Nc2+, but instead of capturing at b7, 6 c5 Rb8 7 Bb5 and Ne5 is more troublesome to black.

5 ... b6

Possibly 5...Qc8 6 Nc3 c6 7 Bd2 Be7 8 Rcl 0-0 is less weakening for black.

6 Nc3 c5?

But this move really tips black overboard. He must hurry to put his king into safety by 6...Be7 and 7...0-0.

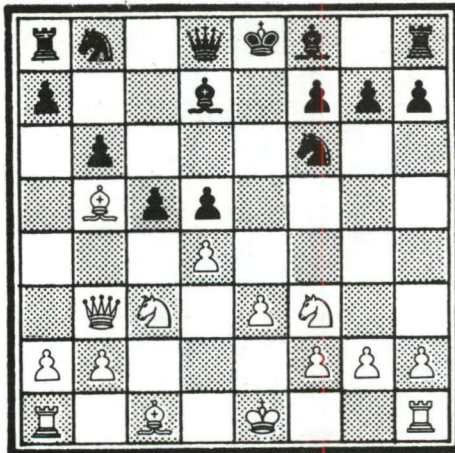
7 cxd5 exd5

8 Bb5+!

White strikes before black can organize his defences.

8 ... Bd7

Otherwise white will win the pawn at d5.

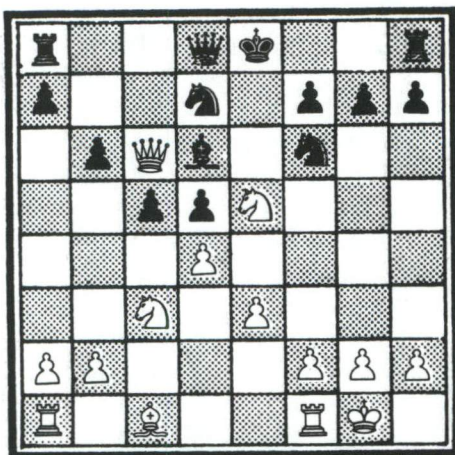


9 Ne5

White could also have captured at d5 by 9 Nxd5 Nxd5 10 Qxd5 Bxb5 11 Qxa8, winning the exchange and a pawn. However, black may have some counterplay as his bishop at b5 prevents white from castling.

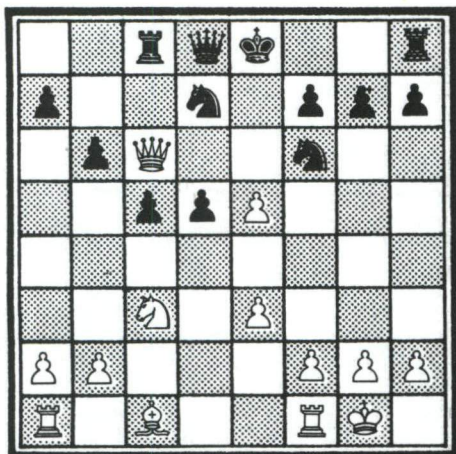
9 ... Bxb5

10 Qxb5+ Nbd7
 11 0-0 Bd6
 12 Qc6!



We are told not to move our queen too often in the opening. However, white is ahead in development, and black has no white squared bishop, which makes it unlikely that the queen will be trapped inside the black camp. Meanwhile, the queen can do a lot of damage, and black is virtually unable to defend his d5 pawn.

12 ... Bxe5
 13 dxe5 Rc8

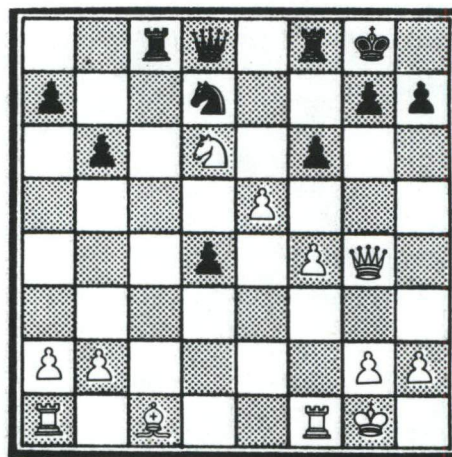


Here 14 Qd6 looks promising, since if the knight at f6 moves, the pawn at d5 falls. Further, the queen at d6 prevents black from castling. However, black may defend by 14...Ng4 15 e6 (if 15 Nxd5 Ngxe5) Ndf6! 16 exf7+ Kxf7 and black escapes with a full skin.

14 Qa4! Ng4??

Finding no good square for the knight, black selects a bad one.

15 Qxg4 0-0
 16 f4 d4
 17 exd4 cxd4
 18 Ne4 f6
 19 Nd6!



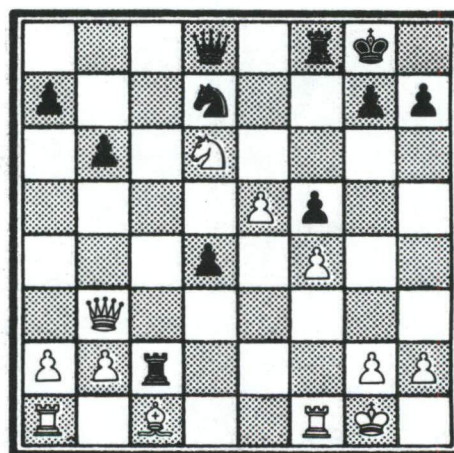
Now the black rook at c8 is attacked, and if black moves it, he loses the other to Qe6+ and Nf7+.

19 ... f5
 20 Qf3

Still keeping the threats on.

20 ... Rc2?

21 Qb3+ and here black lost on time.



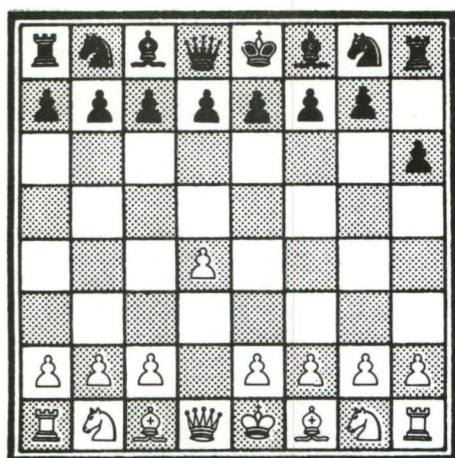
Round 2: the Macho Grob

White: M. Gibbins

Black: M. Basman

1 d4

h6



Start of a global plan to control the central e5 square.

2 e4

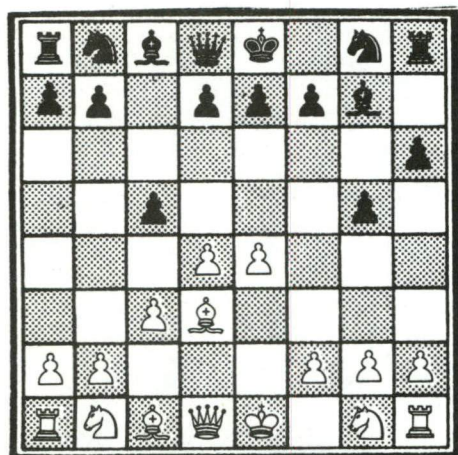
g5

3 Bd3

Bg7

4 c3

c5!



Sacrificing a pawn to remove the white pawn attacking the e5 square. With the white pawn at d4 gone, black will be able to position a knight at e5. White will be unable to drive this piece away from e5 by pawn to f4, because the black pawn at g5 stands guard over that square.

Whether the occupation of a central square is worth the expenditure of a pawn is another matter. It is a question of the dividing line between the material and the positional in chess. A pawn is the smallest unit of material, and on occasion its loss can be compensated for by such factors as development,

central control, piece placing, pawn structure etc.

5 Ne2

White declines the invitation.

5 ...

Nc6

But black insists.

6 dxc5

Qc7

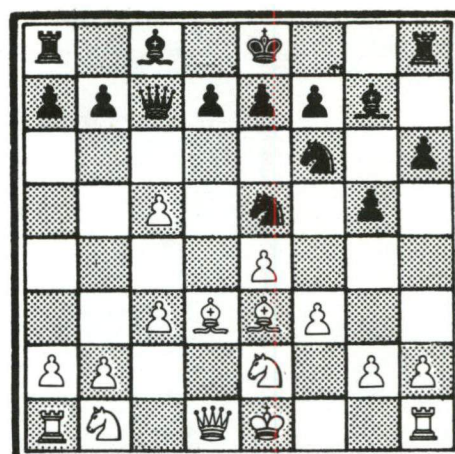
Thematically eyeing the e5 square.

7 Be3

Nf6

8 f3

Ne5



Now the square is occupied.

Should white now castle here, there is an interesting combination at black's disposal: 9 0-0 Neg4?! 10 fxc4 Nxc4, threatening the bishop at e3 and checkmate at h2. Actually, the combination does not work, because white can reply with 11 Rf3! Qxh2+ 12 Kf1 Qh1+ 13 Bg1 Nh2+ 14 Kf2 Nxf3 15 Qxf3, and though black has apparent material equality his pieces are out of action. As this is meant to be an instructional magazine, I suggest you play through this variation a few times to absorb its ideas.

9 Na3

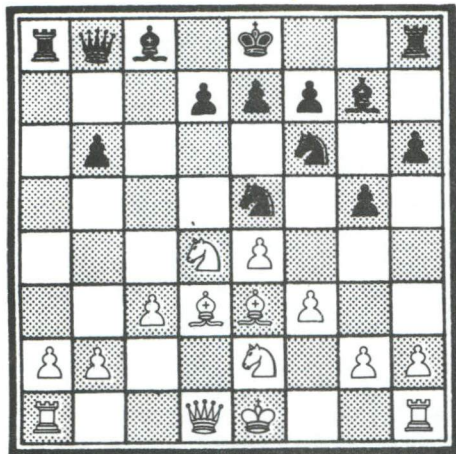
In fact, white does not castle, but makes a natural developing move. He could not have played the more central Nd2, because of the reply... Nxd3+.

9 ...

b6

Black exchanges pawns in order to activate his queen side pieces.

10 Nb5 Qb8
 11 cxb6 axb6
 12 Nbd4



Hereabouts white begins to drift. He makes several knight moves without improving his position.

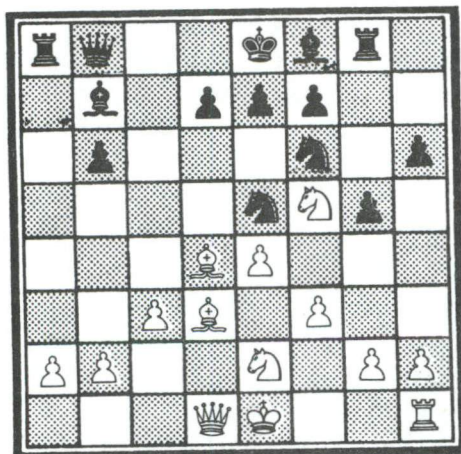
12 ... Rg8

Preparing to use the rook on the g file after the advance of the black pawns on the king side.

13 Nf5 Bf8

This backward move of the bishop nonetheless clears the g line and also protects the weak square at d6, should black later wish to drive the knight away from f5.

14 Bd4 Bb7



Another black piece develops towards the centre. At first sight this loses the pawn at b6, but if white captures by 15 Bxb6, black replies with ...Bxe4 and... Qxb6.

15 Bb5!

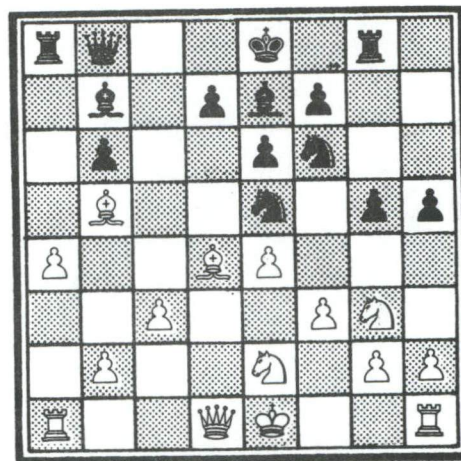
White senses a weakness at d7, where he can checkmate should he succeed in eliminating the two black defensive knights.

15 ... e6

16 Nfg3 Be7

To guard the loose knight at f6, and also to give the king a flight square at f8.

17 a4 h5!?

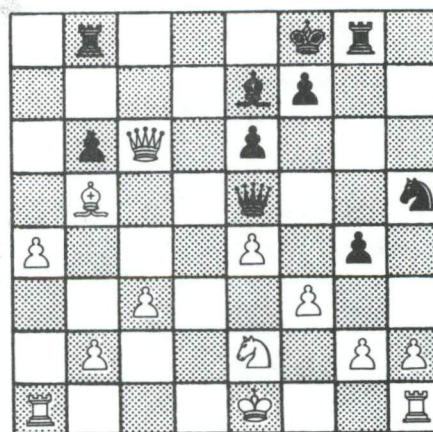


A crisis moment in the struggle.

White now has the opportunity to win two more pawns at the cost of allowing black total domination of e5 and the black squares.

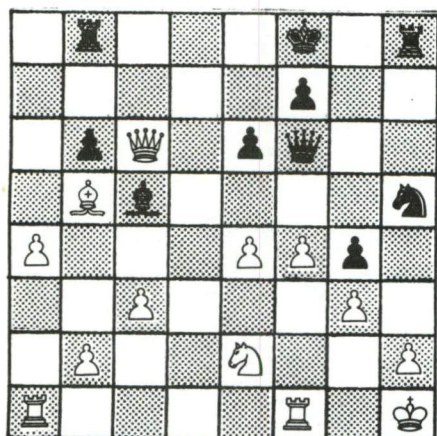
18 Nxh5! Nxh5 19 Bxe5 Qxe5
 20 Qxd7+ Kf8 21 Qxb7 Rb8 22 Qc6 g4!

(variation)



I felt that despite the 3 pawn deficit, black has compensation due to his dark square bind and the uncomfortable white king.

Black threatens to invade here with ...gxf3 and ...Rg2. Should white prevent this by castling king side, black should avoid ...gxf3 because of 24 Rxf3. Also 23 0-0 g3 is not good for black after 24 h3. However, black has other attacking chances: 23 0-0 Bc5+ 24 Kh1 Rh8 (threatening Ng3+ and Qxg3) 25 f4 Qf6 26 g3. (variation)



Do you see a good continuation for black here? Answer at the end of the article.

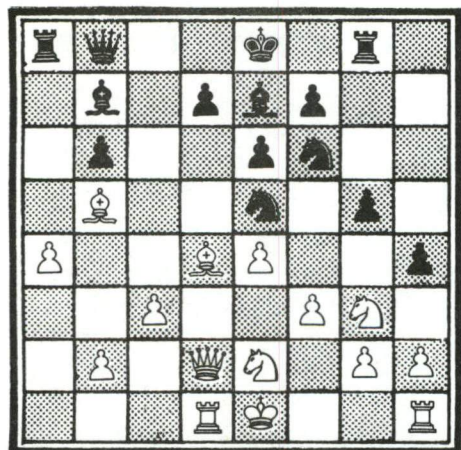
As it happened, white played none of these continuations, and his game rapidly crumbled.

18 Qd2

Too slow.

18 ... h4!

19 Rd1



White goes for a chimeric attack on d7. However, even after 19 Nf1 h3! 20 Bxe5 (20 gxh3 loses to Nxf3+) hxg2! 21 Bxb8 gxh1=Q black is on top.

19 ... hxg3
20 Bxe5 Qxe5
21 Bxd7+ Kf8
22 hxg3 Rd8

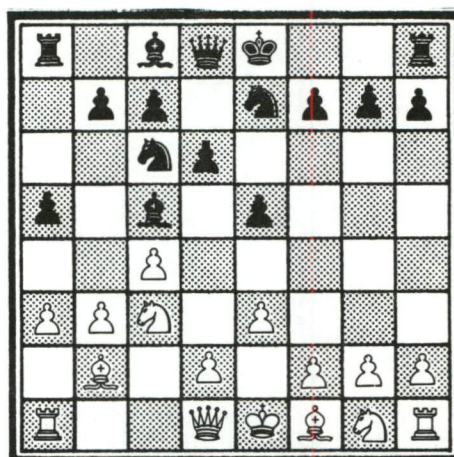
White's attack has come to a full stop, and he is about to lose another piece. The game did not last long.

Round 3: Larsen's opening

White: M. Basmah

Black: S.T.K. Wilkinson

1 b3 e5
2 Bb2 Nc6
3 e3 Bc5
4 c4 d6
5 Nc3 Nge7
6 a3 a5



Black's development of the bishop at c5 is quite active, but frequently the bishop becomes a target for pawn advances.

7 Nf3

White opts for a safe but limited plan of king side development by playing his knight to f3 and then castling. The disadvantage is that he is no longer able to expand on that side of the board.

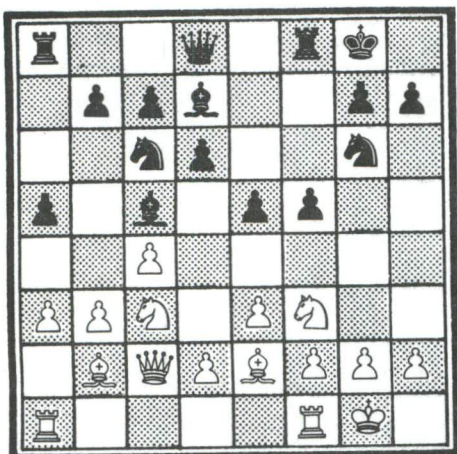
7 ... 0-0

8 Be2 Bd7

Black must be careful not to fall into the trap of playing

8...Be6, which loses a piece to 9 d4 followed by the fork pawn to d5 - an example of piece exposure to pawn advances.

9 0-0 Ng6
10 Qc2 f5

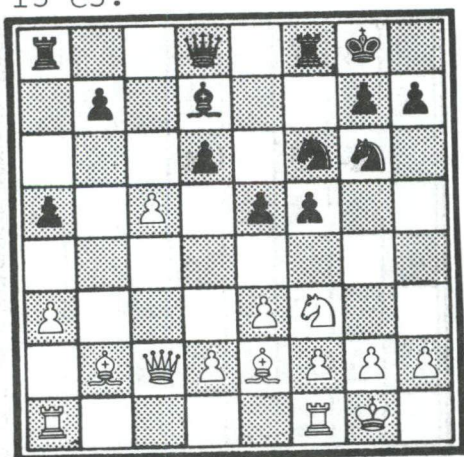


Black has now secured his space advantage on the king side, and his pawns and pieces look poised for a promising attack. Therefore white puts pressure on the middle squares to take the heat off.

11 Nd5 Nce7
12 b4 Nxd5?

Black's first definite mistake, which exchanges his important bishop at c5, and leads to severe weaknesses on the central dark squares.

13 bxc5! Nf6
14 cxd6 cxd6
15 c5!



As in games 1 (see the move 12 Qc6) and game 2 (after the suggested line 18 Nxd5 Nxd5 19 Bxe5 Qxe5), the loss of a bishop causes a weakness on the squares of one

colour. Here black needs to play 15...Qe7 to hold his position together, since after 16 cxd6 Qxd6 he still defends e5 adequately. Instead black attempts a tactical defence which rebounds on him.

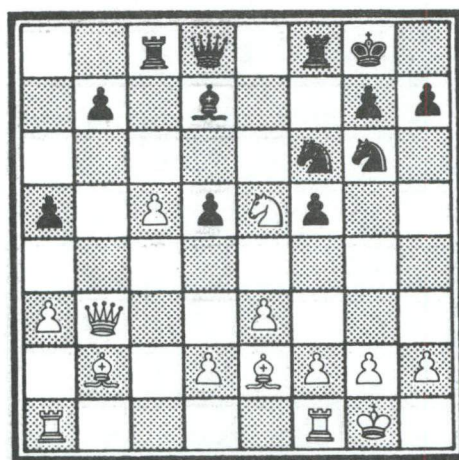
15 ... Rc8?

... Pinning the pawn at c5 but missing a check,

16 Qb3+ d5

After 16...Kh8, white could play cxd6 or play Ng5 threatening Nf7+.

17 Nxe5

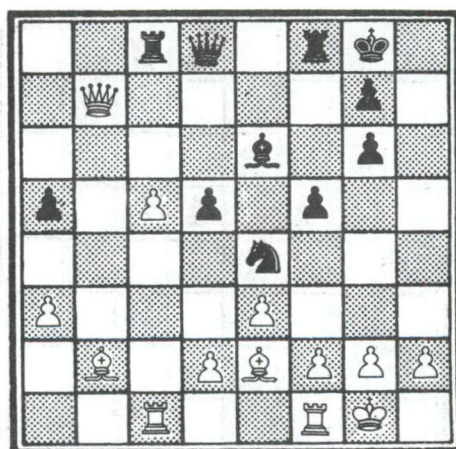


The conquest of the centre square gives white the advantage.

17 ... Be6
18 Racl Ne4

A spirited attempt at counterplay by threatening a knight fork at d2. But the position is too far gone by now.

19 Nxg6 hxg6
20 Qxb7!



White can pick up another pawn because the skewer ... Rb8 is met by 21 Qxg7 mate.

20 ... Rc7

21 Qb6

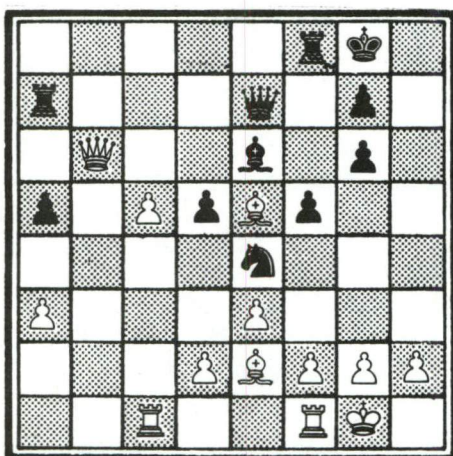
As in game 1, the queen sits heavily on the black position.

21 ... Qe7

22 Be5!

Another threat along the dark squares leaves black no time to play his threat Nxd2.

22 ... Ra7



23 d3 and black resigned, because if he moves his attacked knight, the skewer Bd6 will soon follow.

Round 4: the Polish defence

Beginning this round, the games became more difficult, as I was playing people with several wins tucked under their belts. In fact in this game I came quite close to defeat.

White: Omar Farid

Black: M. Basman

1 d4 b5

The Polish defence. White chooses a quiet line against it.

2 Nf3 Bb7

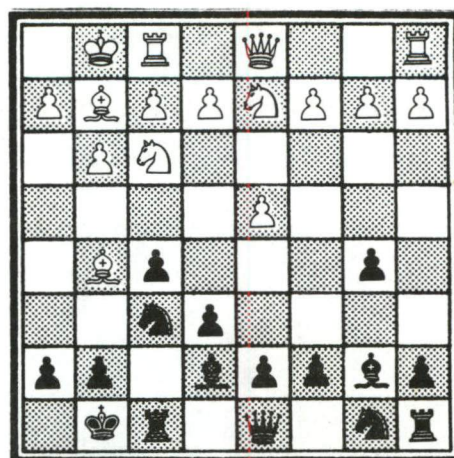
3 g3 e6

4 Bg2 f5

5 0-0 Nf6

6 Bg5 Be7

7 Nbd2 0-0



Both sides have managed to castle, and black currently controls the e4 square and prevents white's immediate expansion in the centre.

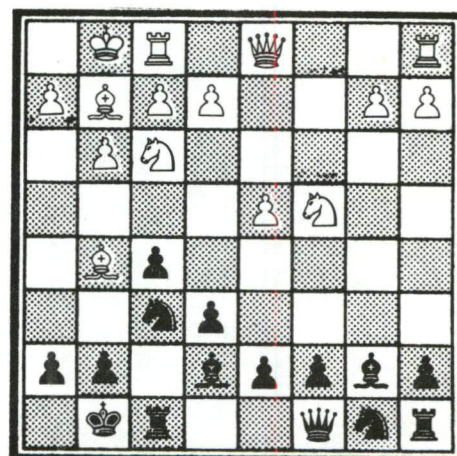
8 c4!?

White has a lead in development, since black's knight is not yet off the back rank, and he seeks to put direct pressure on black's game.

8 ... bxc4

In this way black exchanges a side pawn for a centre pawn, but he remains behind in development.

9 Nxc4 Qc8



Black plays his queen to c8 in order to defend the bishop at b7, and also to allow the queen to come out via the queen side. Possibly the immediate 9...Nc6 (10 Nfe5 Nxe5 11 Bxb7? Nxc4 12 Bxa8 Qxa8) was better.

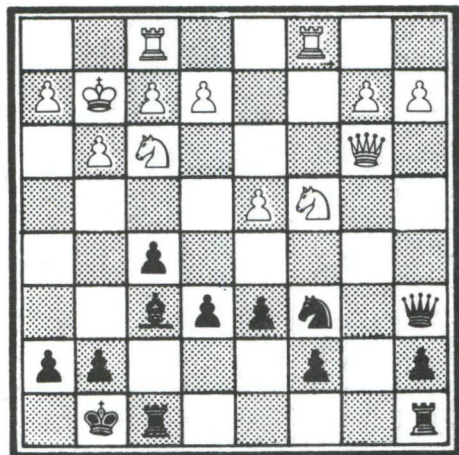
10 Rcl Bd5

11 Bxf6 Bxf6

12 Nfe5	Bxg2
13 Kxg2	Qa6!

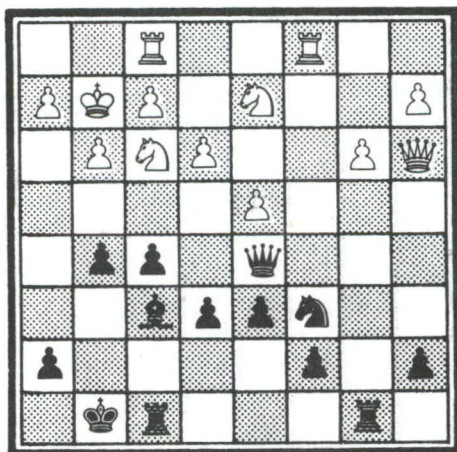
Black is not yet ready to develop the knight at b8.

14 Qb3	d6
15 Nf3	Nc6



At last the knight comes out. Black still has some problems. His pawn at e6 is weak, and the white queen at b3 has her beady eye upon it. The rook at c1 exerts pressure both against the knight at c6 and the pawn at c7. However, black has his advantages too, with possible control of the central white squares, the open b file and a well placed black queen.

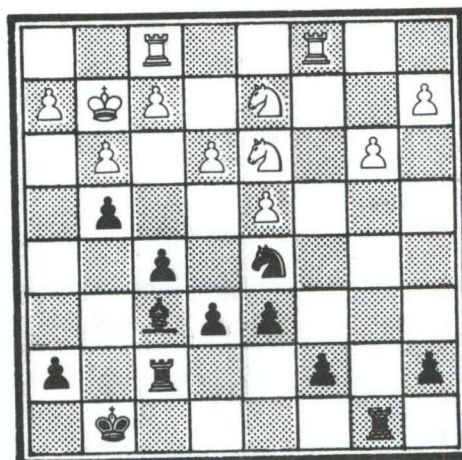
16 e3	Rab8
17 Qa3	Qb5
18 b3	Qd5
19 Nd2	g5



Black has centralised his queen, and now plans a king side pawn roller and an attack. His last move, g5, also has the threat of pawn to g4, winning the knight at f3.

White now takes steps to exchange off the centralised black queen and weaken the attack.

20 Qa6!	Nb4
21 Qc4	g4
22 Qxd5	Nxd5
23 Ne1	Rf7
24 Nd3	



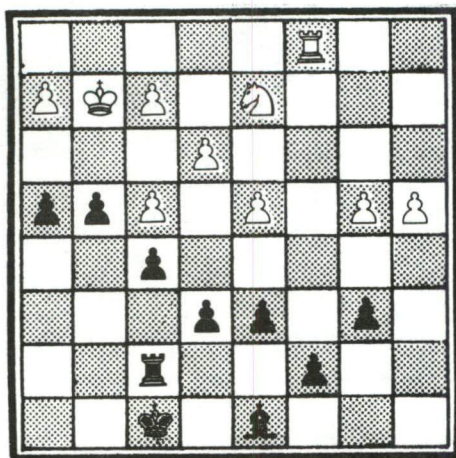
The endgame is approximately equal, with white having pressure down the c file, and black having a dominant knight at d5, which, incidentally, defends the weak c7 pawn.

However, as white is threatening to exchange off the knight by 25 Nf4, black should have prevented this by playing 24...Bg5!, preparing to answer Nf4 by capturing with the bishop.

24 ... h5?

After this weak move, the game goes definitely in white's favour.

25 Nf4	Nxf4+
26 gxf4	h4
27 Rc6	Rb6
28 Rfc1	Bd8
29 a4	Kf8
30 Rxb6	axb6
31 b4!	



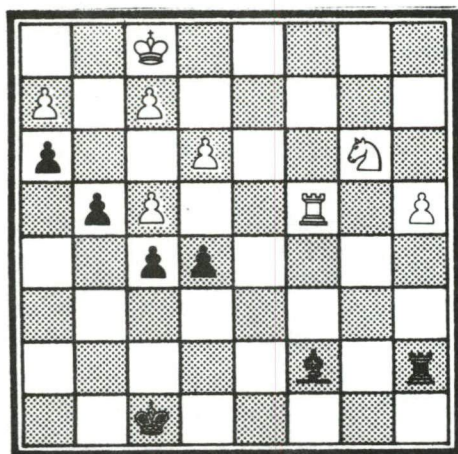
Worse and worse. Apart from the passive bishop at d8, which he could put up with, black has the prospect of a white passed 'a' pawn looming before him. Therefore he decides on a pawn sacrifice for freedom.

31 ... h3+
32 Kf1 c5!

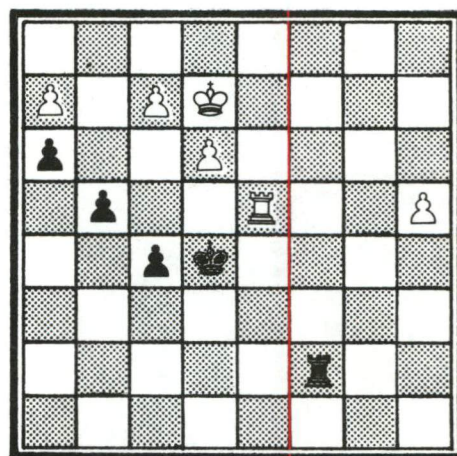
Though black loses a pawn here, he frees his bishop and obtains good drawing chances. In the first place, the bishop may be superior to the knight on an open board, and in the second, endings with rooks on the board can often be drawn even if one side is a pawn behind.

33 dxc5 dxc5
34 bxc5 bxc5
35 Rxc5 Ra7
36 Rc4 Bc7
37 Nb3 e5

Trying to exchange the pawns to increase the drawing chances.



38 Nc5 Ke7
39 Nd3 exf4
40 Nxf4 Bxf4
41 Rxf4 Ke6
42 Ke2 Rc7
43 Rd4 Ke5



A key moment. To secure winning chances, white needs to place his rook behind his passed pawn, and he can do this by playing 44 a5!, followed by Ra4. However, white, who has avoided too much risk during this game, does not seize this opportunity.

44 f4+? gxf3+?

Had black realised how bad black's last move was, he would have played 44...Ke6 here, leaving white with the awkward problem of defending his pawn at h2 and preventing black from gaining his own passed pawn by a timely ...g3.

45 Kxf3 Rc2
46 Kg3 Rc3
47 Kf3 Ra3
48 Rh4 Kf6
49 Rxh3 Rxa4

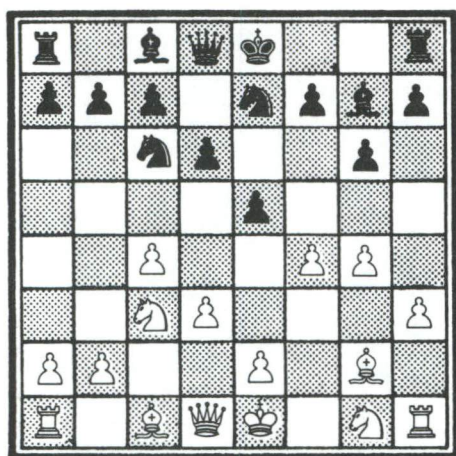
and the game was shortly drawn. With the pawns all on the same side of the board, and the black king stationed in front of them, there is little chance of a white victory now,

Round 5: the Macho Grob as white

White: M. Basman

Black: Tasker

- | | |
|-------|------|
| 1 g4 | g6 |
| 2 Bg2 | Bg7 |
| 3 h3 | d6 |
| 4 c4 | e5 |
| 5 Nc3 | Ne7 |
| 6 d3 | Nbc6 |
| 7 f4 | |

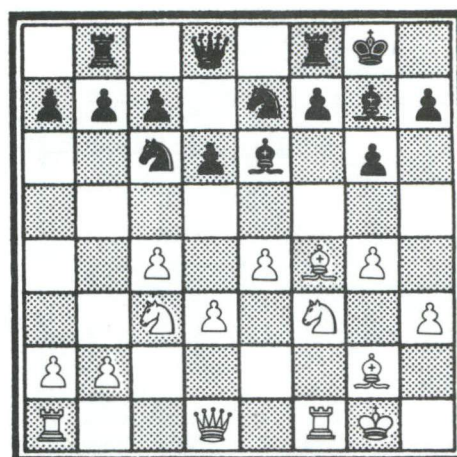


What we are seeing is a Sicilian Close in reverse, with white having played the moves g4 and h3 instead of simply g3. This gives him added space on the king side, and, of course, added commitments. His last move attempts to increase his space control of the king side to gigantic proportions. Black at first does not rise to the bait, which he could have done with pawn thrusts such as ...h5 or ...f5, but continues with quiet development.

- | | |
|-------|-----|
| 7 ... | Be6 |
| 8 Nf3 | Rb8 |
| 9 e4 | |

Now black has to react, because white is threatening to roll on with pawn to f5.

- | | |
|---------|------|
| 9 ... | exf4 |
| 10 Bxf4 | O-O |
| 11 O-O | |

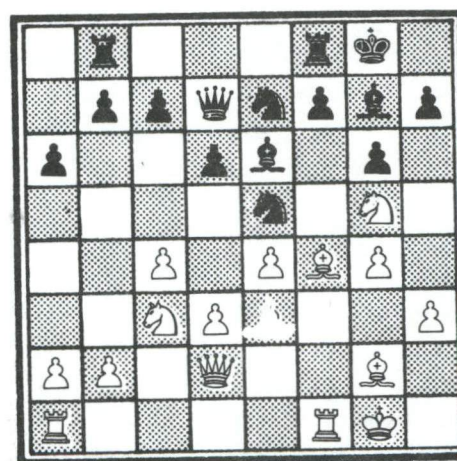


Apparently, white is doing well, with good development, better centre control, and the open f file. But now black begins to make good use of the central squares in his control at e5 and d4.

- | | |
|--------|-----|
| 11 ... | a6 |
| 12 a4 | Qd7 |
| 13 Qd2 | |

White would like to advance with d4 here, but he cannot yet do so, as his pawn at c4 would then be hanging.

- | | |
|--------|------|
| 13 ... | Ne5! |
| 14 Ng5 | |



White avoids the exchange of knights, and positions the knight on the g5 square, where it eyes the bishop at e6 and black's h7 pawn. White is not in a hurry to capture this bishop, and if forced to do so by 14...h6 15 Nxe6 fxe6, he will then be able to pick off the pawn at h6 with his queen and bishop.

- | | |
|--------|------|
| 14 ... | N7c6 |
|--------|------|

15 Kh1

Nd4!

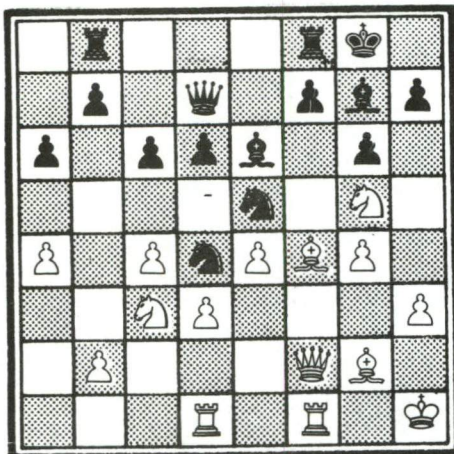
Another knight moves into a strong central position. Black's game is beginning to look promising.

16 Rad1

c6?

Black's play is not active enough here, and white is able to recover the initiative that seemed to be slipping from his grasp.

17 Qf2!



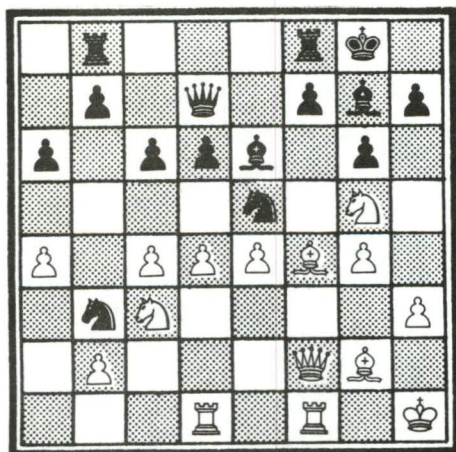
Apart from the obvious threat to capture at d4, white also hopes to play Qh4 and threaten mate at h7.

17 ...

Nb3?

A weak answer. 17...c5 had to be played, though after 18 Qh4 h6 19 Nxe6 fxe6 20 Bxh6 white wins a pawn. This was the best choice, for black still maintains his strong central knights.

18 d4!



This central advance demolishes black's game. He should now give up a piece for 3 pawns

by 18...Nxc4 19 d5 cxd5 20exd5 Bxg4 21 hxg4 Qxg4, when he has some chances against the open white king.

18 ...

Bxc4?

With this move black gets the material equivalent of a rook and pawn against two pieces, but his position falls apart.

19 dxe5

Bxf1

20 Bxf1

d5

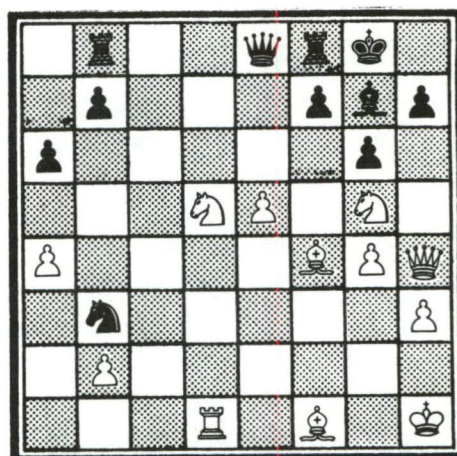
21 exd5

cxd5

22 Nxd5

Qe8

23 Qh4



Though only 23 moves have been played, both sides are now down to their last few minutes. Unfortunately for black, white's game is so overwhelming it is difficult for him to make enough blunders.

23 ...

h6

24 Ne4

Threatening a knight fork at f6 winning the black queen.

24 ...

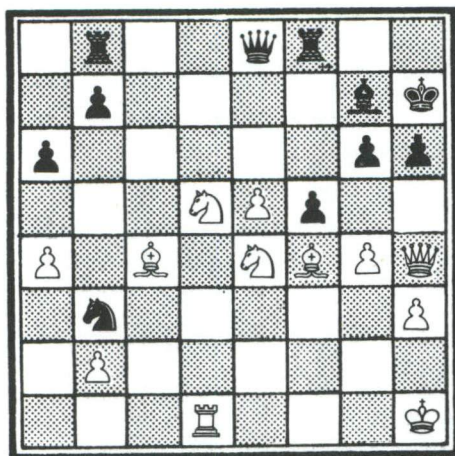
f5

25 Bc4!

Yet another threat to win the poor beknighted black queen, this time with a discovered check.

25 ...

Kh7



26 Ng5+?

26 Nf6+ Rxf6 27 Nxf6+ Bxf6
28 Qxh6 mate would have
been more effective.

26 ... Kh8

27 Bxb3

Why not?

27 ... fxg4

28 e6 Rxf4

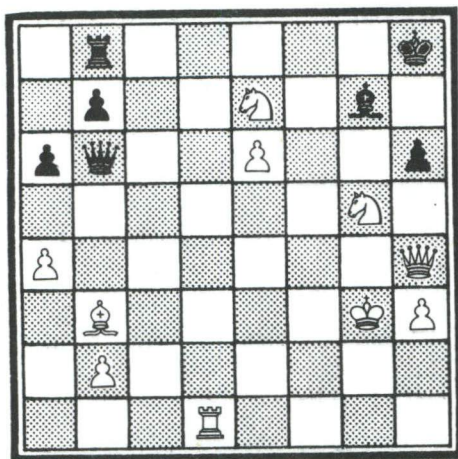
29 Nxf4 Qc6+

30 Kh2 g3+

31 Kxg3 Qb6

32 Nxg6+ Kg8

33 Ne7+ Kh8



32... Ke8 would also
have lost to 33 Nh7+ Ke8
34 Qh5+ Kxe7 35 Qf7++.

34 Nf7+ Kh7

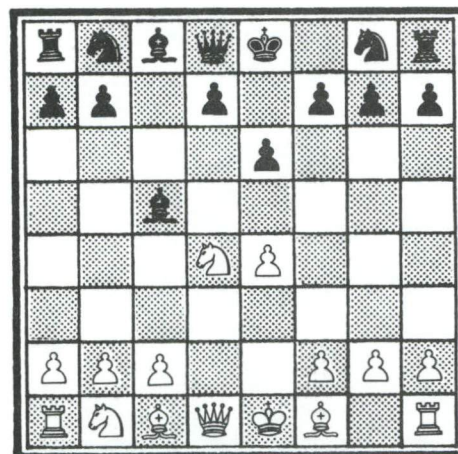
35 Qe4++

Round 6: the Bc5 Sicilian

White: Oregbu

Black: M. Basman

1 e4 c5
2 Nf3 e6
3 d4 cxd4
4 Nxd4 Bc5



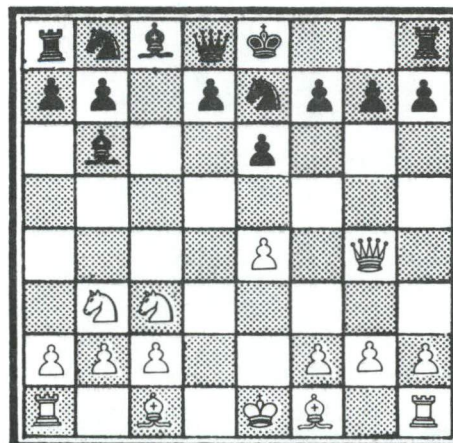
The Bishop c5 opening, which I thought of about 15 years ago, has yet to find its way into the opening books. Why should such a natural move be so universally condemned? The reason is that black is meant to preserve his bishop to protect the weakened square at d6, and not bring it out so carelessly to c5. All very subtle...

5 Nb3 Bb6

6 Nc3 Ne7

One of the points of playing the bishop to c5 is to allow the knight to come to e7 to permit an eventual f5 pawn advance by black.

7 Qg4



A daring move like 7 Qg4 is unlikely to succeed against black's opening, and white will probably only lose time and find his pieces offside. I intended to play here 7...0-0 8 Bh6 Ng6, but as sometimes happens when you are thinking of two moves at once, you play them in the wrong order -especially in quick play.

7 Ng6

I didn't mean to play this move.

8 f4 0-0

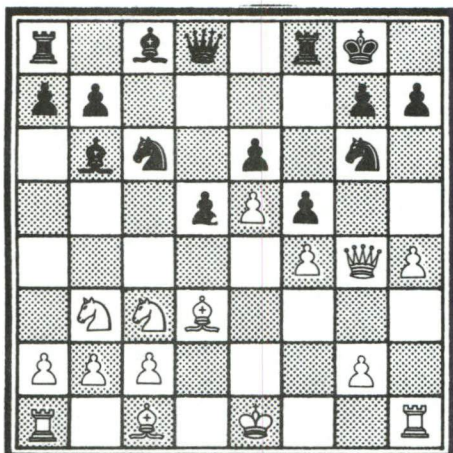
9 Bd3 d5

10 e5

White must lock up the position, because if he continues with 10 f5 exf5 11 exf5, he gets thrashed down the centre lines with Re8+.

10 ... Nc6

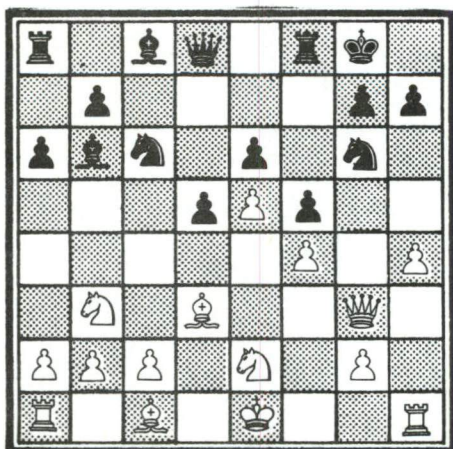
11 h4 f5



White's attack is still quite dangerous, so black is forced to make this blocking move. However, with the position blocked, he is now unable to take advantage of white's time wasting queen sortie...

12 Qg3 a6

13 Nce2



The position now resembles a French defence, where the question of who has the advantage depends on who controls the d4 square. With his last move, white threatens to play c3, Be3, and finally Nd4, planting pieces firmly on that outpost square. Hence black's blunt answer, which is to occupy the square with a pawn of his own.

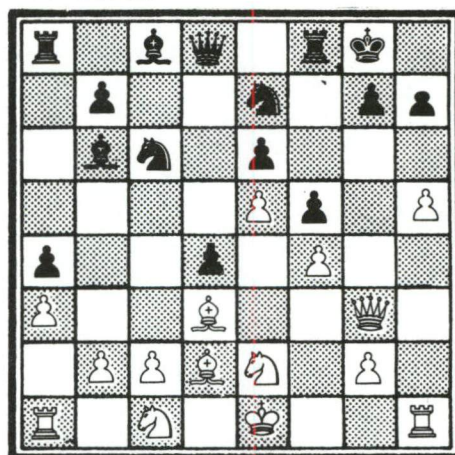
13 ... d4

14 Bd2 a5

15 h5 Nge7

16 a3 a4

17 Nbcl



White's pieces have now engineered themselves into a magnificent tangle, but - as I have already mentioned, he can afford to do so in this blocked position.

17 ... Nd5

In some cases the knight threatens to enter at e3.

18 Qh3

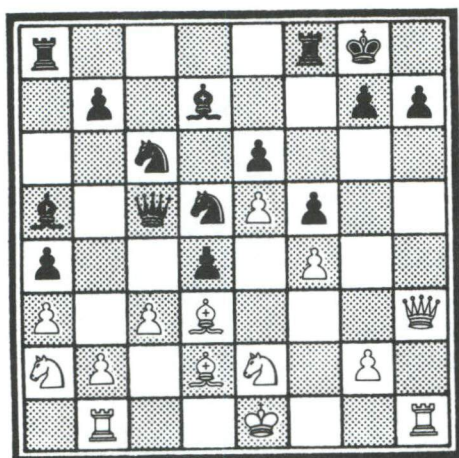
White is persistent in trying for his king side attack, and now threatens g4. Such single-mindedness is worrying, and sure enough, white eventually does conjure up an attack of sorts.

18 ... Ba5

19 c3 Qb6

20 Rb1 Qc5

21 Na2 Bd7



A quite involved position has arisen. Both sides grind away at each other like a pair of overweight boxers, without either player able to deliver a really telling blow.

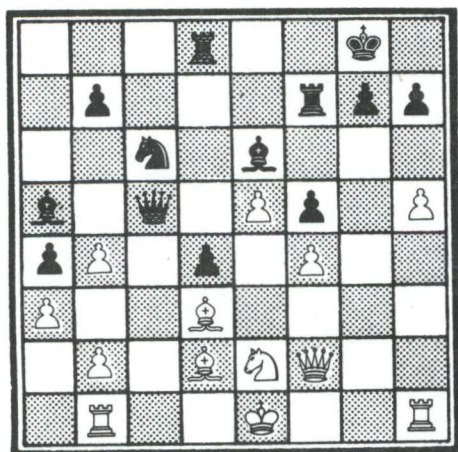
22 g4 Rad8
23 gxf5 exf5
24 Qg3 Rf7

Having opened up the g file, white now turns his attention to the g7 square.

25 Qf2!

But now an unexpected switch threatens to win the black pawn at d4. However, white's game is fundamentally too disorganized to allow him to gain a real advantage.

25 ... Be6
26 Nb4 Ndx b4
27 cxb4

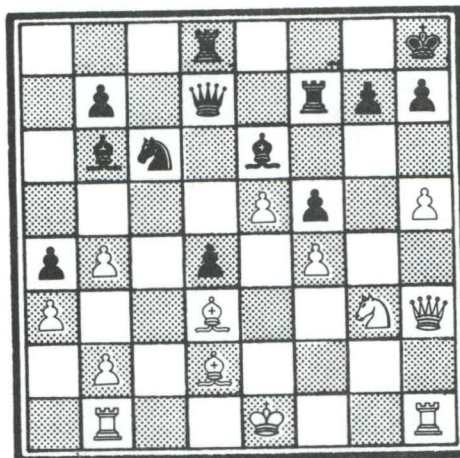


Apparently forking two black pieces, but this is not so.

27 ... Qd5

Hitting back at the loose rook at h1.

28 Rg1 Bb6
29 Qg2 Qd7
30 Ng3 Kh8
31 Qh3?



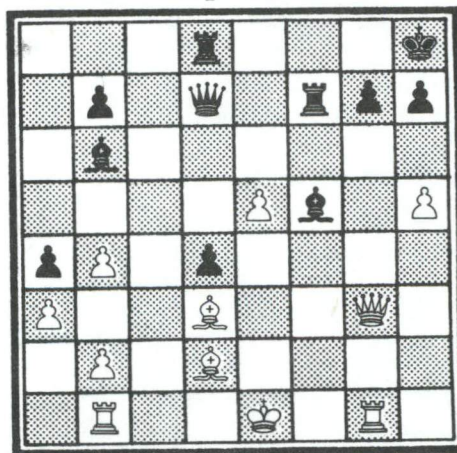
A mistake which allows black to open the game in his favour.

31 ... Nx e5!
32 fxe5 f4

This discovery against the white queen wins back the piece.

33 Qh4 fxg3
34 Qxg3 Bf5

Black is trying to swap the bishops and clear a path towards the white king at e1.



35 h6!

White too does not hang about, and has finally drummed up unpleasant threats against the black king,

35 ... Re8!

Counterattacking against white's king at e1.

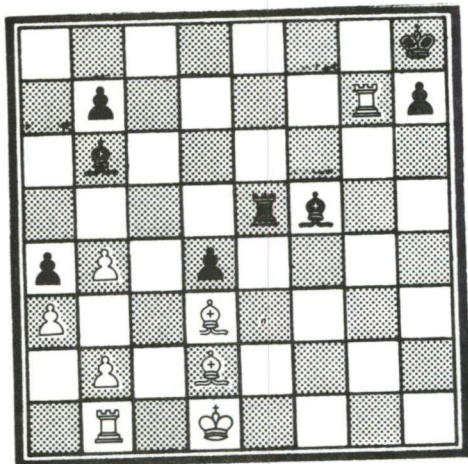
36 hxg7+ Rxg7

Here I was worried that white would play 37 Bg5, but then the simple ...Bxd3 38 Bf6 Bg6 is good enough.

37 Qxg7+ Qxg7

38 Rxg7 Rxe5+

39 Kd1



39 ... Bxd3?

A miscalculation that allows white to escape. After 39... Kxg7, black would have been a pawn ahead with the better position.

40 Rxb7 Bxb1

There is probably nothing better now.

41 Rxb6

And after several more moves, which were unrecorded, a position was reached in which white had an extra pawn on the queen side, but no winning chances due to the opposite coloured bishops.

The game was therefore agreed drawn.

POPULAR CHESS is published several(?) times a year. It specialises in articles which are easier to follow and more beneficial to the average player. The chess world is an elitist place, and the general reaction of top players to this problem is not to realise that it exists.

I intend to publish Popular until issue Number 18, after which I will decide whether to continue publication or not. My thanks to patient subscribers who have borne its erratic appearances.

Subscription rates:

Rabbits Review (predecessor to Popular Chess)
Issues 1-12 90p each
Full set £8.40

Rabbits Review
Issues 13-21 £1 each
Full set £8.30

Popular Chess
Issues 1-12 £1 each
Full set £10.80

Popular Chess
Subscription issues 13-18
£6.50
Single issues £1.20 each.

All prices post free from
Audio Chess, 7 Billockby
Close, Chessington, Surrey
KT9 2ED (Tel 01-397-1826)

Make cheques payable to
Audio Chess.

Answer to puzzle from game 2:
Black wins by ...Nxg3+ 2 Nxg3
Rxh2+; 3 Kxh2 Qh4+ 4 Kg2 Qh3++.

ON THE REBOUND
An exciting game from
Victor Mathias

Game 37 Alan v Victor Oct 1987

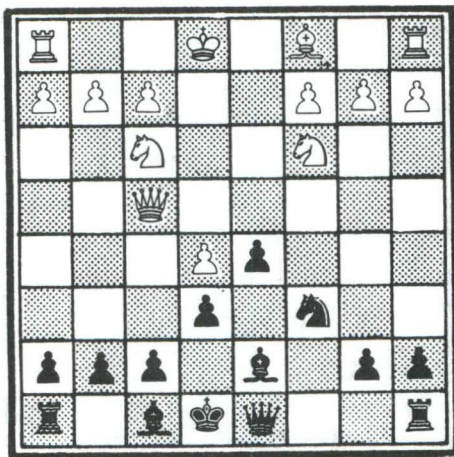
1 P-K4 P-K3

My first try with the French as Black. Alan has done well with it against me when he was Black.

2 P-Q4 P-Q4
3 P-K5 P-QB4
4 N-KB3 PxP
5 QxP N-QB3
6 B-QN5 N-K2
7 N-B3? ...

Too slow, I think. This enables me to break the pin next move, force BxN from Alan, then challenge Alan's Q and free my Kingside.

7 ... B-Q2
8 BxN NxP
9 Q-KB4 ...



Although the White Queen now looks rather exposed, it is also a powerful unsheathed weapon facing Black's King; and Black must play the next few moves with great care.

9 ... P-KR3

Laying claim to the potentially vital g5 square.

10 N-QN5 ...

Clearly wanting to put the Knight on d6, but my reply foils this idea.

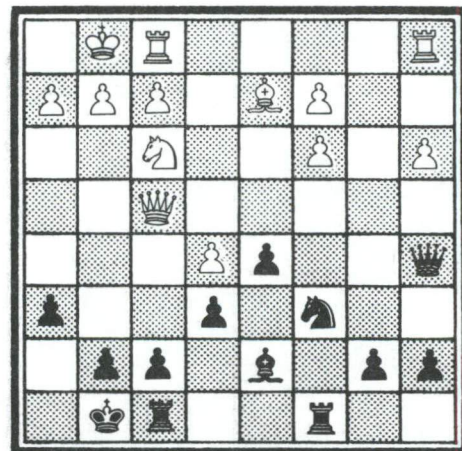
10 ... Q-R4+
11 N-B3 ...

An ignominiously instant retreat, but the only move that saves Alan's bacon (or in this case his horsemeat).

11 ... B-N5
12 B-Q2 ...

This game (being played O.T.B.) was adjourned for a fortnight at this point. Castling kingside is the obvious next move for Black (I'd have preferred castling the other way but Alan would then have won my KBP); as I said to Alan, it has its dangers, and indeed the next phase of the game proved me right.

12 ... O-O
13 O-O QR-B1
14 P-QR3 BxN
15 PxB?! ...



The immediate effect of this apparently silly move (why not BxB?) is to land Alan with **three** weak queenside pawns; but I later accorded the move an exclamation mark when I saw White's powerful move 18 which it was preparing for

15 ... Q-B2

My Queen is going to be needed back in defence and is best removed immediately from the firing-line of Alan's Bishop.

16 Q-N3 ...

As is quite normal against the French, White puts his Queen on the g-file, pinning my KNP and therefore threatening 17 BxP!!

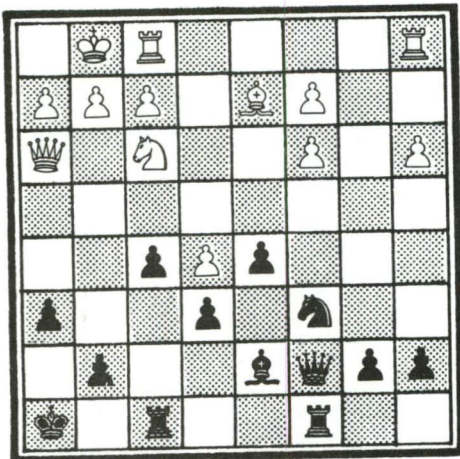
16 ... K-R1

My King sidles into the corner and reflects mournfully on the inadequacy of the defences in front of it.

17 Q-R3! ...

Removing my protection of the strategically vital g5 square. I thought long and hard. Now something has got to give....

17 ... P-B4



The best I could find in a position fraught with difficulties. Now if Alan takes the pawn e.p., I recapture with my Rook and guard h6. If, on the other hand, he doesn't do **something** quickly, 18 ... P-B5 blocks the Bishop's diagonal along which he is lining up his attack. My move, in short, is more of a provocation than an adequate defence.

18 BxP!! ...

Here it comes!! Alan rides into the attack yet again with a sacrifice in front of my King. I must emphasize that this is in no way an unsound attack, for Alan strips away my King's thin defences **and** recoups his material before long - hence, the double exclamation marks.

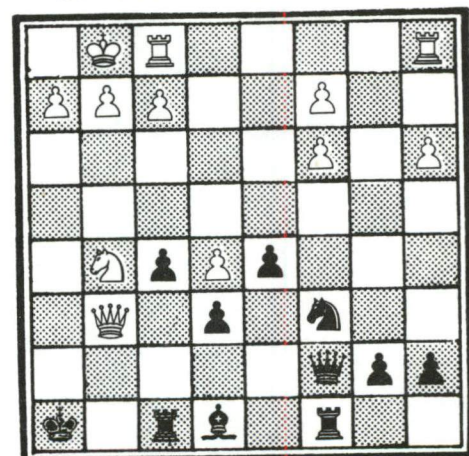
18 ... PxB
19 QxP+ K-N1
20 Q-N6+ ...

A drawback of my move 17 was that it 'gave' Alan the use of g6 on which to further his attack; as a compensation to me, however, my move 17 also gave my cornered King a possible bolt-hole on f7.

20 ... K-R1
21 N-N5! ...

Treatening mate in 1 and thereby winning (as a start) my e-pawn (my move 17 was now looking like a blunder)

21 ... B-K1



The only move.

22 Q-R6+ K-N1
23 NxP! ...

This took me by surprise as I had been expecting Alan to take my King's Pawn with his Queen, thereby giving check at the same time; but this move abjuring the check, simply

forks Rook and Queen, leaving me with a denuded King and the exchange down - this game looked as if it was coming to a quick and painful end for me.

23 ... Q-B2

At least avoiding ...Q-R2??

24 QxR++

24 NxR QxN

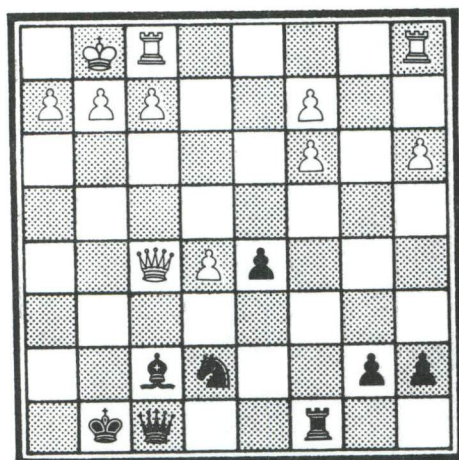
25 Q-K6!+ B-B2

The only move. Alan was threatening to take my remaining Rook; now all that he gets is my f-pawn instead.

26 QxBP ...

The next thing I did was high comedy - or farce, depending on which way you look at it. I played ...BxP and Alan pointed out that I was taking my own pawn. I ascribed my mistake to the tension of my situation taking its toll.

26 ... N-K2!



Let's look at the position. Alan has given up two minor pieces and in return has (a) my Rook and 4 of my pawns - a winning material lead in itself (b) got my King right into the open and (c) has no less than **four connected kingside passed pawns**. Yet the game is not over, as my move 26 demonstrates. Note that Alan has only **one** developed piece out on the field: his Queen - and he is not

going to mate me with that alone. All my remaining forces, on the other hand, are well-placed for counter-attack. He, as has been pointed out, has chronic pawn-weaknesses on the queenside. My move 26 attacks his Queen and uncovers an attack by my Rook along the open c-file.

27 Q-B6 ...

With this move, Alan threatens 28 P-K6!! against my pinned Bishop which would force my immediate resignation.

27 ... R-B3!

Developing my Rook further, defending against Alan's threat, and hitting his Queen.

28 Q-B3 Q-QB1

Leaving my Knight unprotected; **but** giving my King room to move sideways via f8 to relative safety, and renewing my threat to Alan's c3 pawn, which Alan cannot defend. (The latent power of this move, which rapidly becomes apparent, I confess I did not foresee at this stage).

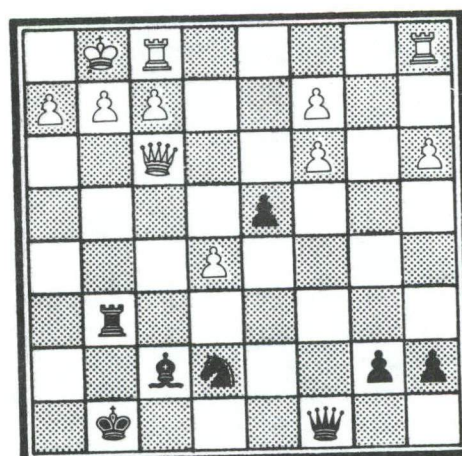
29 Q-N3+ R-KN3

I had a choice of no less than four good replies to this check. (As I said, however, to Alan at the time: "It's too late now for mere fooling moves.")

30 Q-B3 ...

What a pity he didn't play Q-R3??? QxQ!!

30 ... P-Q5!



This move is not what it appears.

31 PxP B-Q4!!

So: my previous move, far from being a veiled attempt to infiltrate to Alan's 7th rank, was merely aimed at vacating d5 for my Bishop.

At this juncture, I went off to make the teas, leaving Alan deep in thought. He went on thinking while I made the tea, while I brought it in, and even then continued to ponder. At length, with a sigh, he played:

32 QxB+ ...

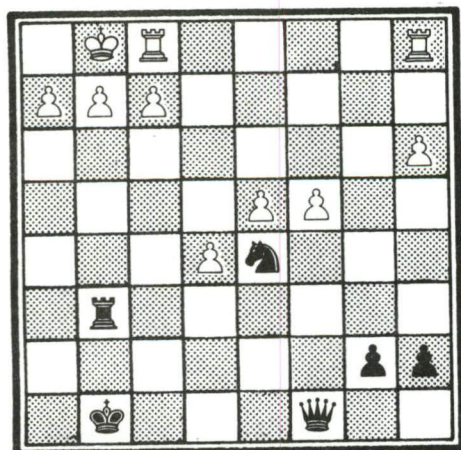
saying: "I saw that move coming earlier on, but then forgot about it."

32 ... NxQ

I thought my Knight beautifully placed on its central d5 square, reckoning that it couldn't for the moment be challenged by P-QB4 because of my Queen's hold on that file. I'd happily have left my Knight there (incidentally blocking the **fifth** of Alan's connected passed pawns!), if Alan hadn't come up with his move 33.

33 P-QB4?!...

I realised now that after 34 ... QxP either Rook to c1 is strong. But, as I say, this brave sortie rebounded on Alan for it goaded me into deciding to re-position my Knight, with fatal results for my opponent.



33 ... N-B5!!

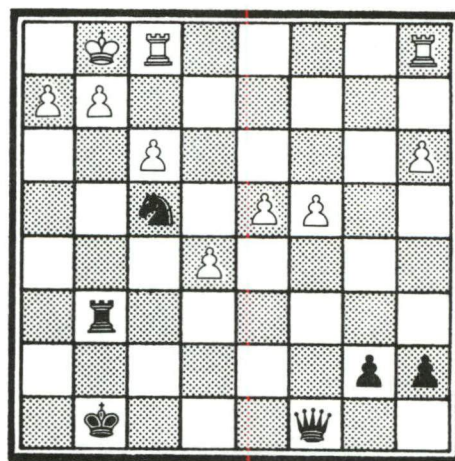
When I played this move, Alan saw its strength better than I did and said unashamedly: "I'm probably done for now."

(See whether you agree with Alan's observation.)

34 P-B3 ...

Alan, in a fit of nerves, picked up his Queen's Rook to move it to a2 and then asked my indulgence so that he could play the text-move instead (... "which I'd meant to play. I'm sorry." I said: "OK, just this once. This is a friendly game, it's true. But don't do it again.").

Alan's final choice of move means that I can now safely take his c-pawn and capture his d-pawn with check next if he challenges along the c-file; **BUT** I have something immeasurably stronger...



34 ... RxP+!
35 K-R1 Q-R6!!
36 Resigns.

It is mate next move.

After this game, I lead Alan by 22 points to 15.

59 Goodhart Way,
West Wickham,
Kent,
BR4 0ET
25th October 1987

An Unsolicited Testimonial

Dear Mr. Basman,

I am currently ungraded as I don't play enough chess - less than a dozen games in the last two years. I also have little time for study, and therefore I need a limited opening repertoire. Against 1 e4 I have tried the French, but don't like the passive Queen's Bishop, so I switched to the Sicilian Najdorf and then the Taimanov variation, with limited success. And what to do about 1 d4?

In May of this year, I took my son to compete in the Abbey National South East regional school's final at Esher. Browsing through the chess literature on display I picked up 'Play the St. George' and read the blurb: "...universal defence...Karpov's defeat by Miles in 1980". Eagerly I bought a copy from you, and read it with great interest, especially as some lines seemed like a Sicilian but with greater flexibility.

A new season approached, and a couple of weeks ago, I sent for your audio tapes on St. George's Opening and played through them. And so to last Tuesday; I drew Black in the London Bank's Chess League against an opponent graded 150+, and I enclose the result.

Wow! Have you thought of TV or Radio commercials?

"And finally, Mrs. Smith, would you swap your new formula St. George for these two packets of ordinary defences"

"No thank you, Jimmy, since I've been using new St. George, my opponents have come up whiter than White."

"So there we are - use new St. George and you won't get the blues with Black. Satisfaction guaranteed or your money back."

Please rush me your tape on the Polish defence under plain wrapper. I am over 18. (Although my son came second in the U-11 section at Esher, I don't think he's ready for such meaty stuff yet. Besides, he might beat me with it!). Please also send me a sample issue of Popular Chess. I enclose £4.75.

Yours sincerely,
Ray Pink.

P.S. I must catch up with your Grob tapes sometime. I played it briefly in the late '70s after reading C.F. Bloodgood's book, which was useful although flawed - unfortunately the improvents I found were anti-Grob!

P.P.S. My wife has just looked over my shoulder and asked me to tell you that she likes the musical interludes on the tapes!

T.Hyam v. R.Pink
London Banks Chess League
20/10/87

1. e4 e6
2. d4 a6
3. c3 b5
4. Be3 Bb7
5. Nd2 Nf6
6. Bd3 d6

Preparing ...c5, although I considered playing it immediately.

7. f4 ...

A double-edged move which didn't work out in this game; the long white diagonal is weakened, and Black's king is not committed to the kingside.

7. ... c5
8. Nf3 Nc6 (?)

I think ...Ng4 with the possibility of ...Qh4+ would have been embarrassing for White here. Perhaps also this Knight should come to d7.

9. h3 Be7
10. O-O Qc7
11. Nh2 Qb6
12. Ndf3 h6

Preparing ...O-O-O and a king side counter-attack.

13. Qe1 O-O-O
14. Qf2 Nb8

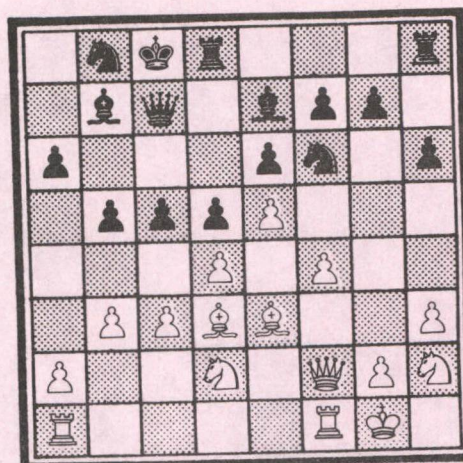
Pressing again on the e-pawn.

15. Nd2 Qc7
16. b3 ...

Too slow, but White is now floundering for a plan. Line opening moves such as dxc or f5 would favour Black here. Now Black's position begins to come alive.

16. ... d5!
17. e5 ...

or 17. exd5 Nxd5



17. ... Ne4!
18. Bxe4 dxe4
19. Rfc1 f5
20. a4 ...

Black would be quite happy with 20. dxc ... Rd3 threatening ...Rxe5 and ...Bxf5.

20. ... g5
21. Qe2 Qc6

Not only protecting b5 but loading the long diagonal.

22. axb5 axb5
23. dxc5 ...

23. Ra5? fails to 23. ... cxd4! and White's c-pawn is pinned. But now, White's position starts to collapse.

23. ... gxf4
24. Bxf4 Rhg8

Suddenly, everything is pointing at g2.

25. Nh1 Bxc5+
26. Kh2 ...

or 26. Ne3 Bxe3 27. Qxe3 Rxd2! 28. Qxd2 e3, or 26. Be3 Bxe3

26. ... e3!
27. Nf3 Qe4
28. Bxe3 f4
29. Nf3-d2 Rxc2++